

AIR-SEA COMBAT

THE BATTLE OF LEYTE GULF

The warfare between the Japanese Imperial Navy and the US Navy in the Pacific during World War II was remarkable for the significant role of aircraft and the epic scale of the combat. The Battle of Leyte Gulf in October 1944 was one of the largest sea battles ever fought.

By autumn 1944 Japanese naval aviation was a battered remnant of the force that had shocked the United States with its attack on Pearl Harbor almost three years earlier. Japan still possessed an impressive array of battleships and cruisers, but without adequate air cover, a sortie by these heavily gunned warships had become almost suicidal. Nonetheless, when the United States began amphibious landings on Leyte Island in the Japanese-occupied Philippines on 20 October, the Imperial Navy sent every available vessel to attack the landing force. The Japanese divided their striking forces in two, one sailing south of Leyte Island and the other to the north. Land-based aircraft on the Philippines would supply air cover, while Japan's few remaining carriers were used as a decoy. Without their aircraft they headed away from the action, in the hope that the carriers of Admiral William F. Halsey, Jr.'s Third Fleet would follow.

The Japanese southern force, including two battleships and four cruisers, was ambushed by Admiral Thomas Kinkaid's Seventh Fleet while attempting the passage of the Surigao Strait on the night of 24–25 October. American destroyers and PT boats first made torpedo runs, scoring a series of hits that sank the battleship *Fuso* with all hands. The Japanese then encountered the American main force of six battleships and eight cruisers, some equipped with advanced radar fire control that allowed them to hit Japanese warships at a range of over 18,280 metres (20,000 yards) in the dark. The second Japanese battleship,

Yamashiro, was among the ships sunk by armour-piercing shells. Only a handful of crew survived.

Meanwhile, the approach of the other Japanese naval force through the Sibuyan Sea on 24 October had triggered a fierce air–sea battle. Halsey's carrier aircraft swarmed to attack the battleship *Musashi*, one of the largest, most powerfully gunned warships ever built. Hit by 19 bombs and 17 torpedoes in five successive air strikes, the massive ship sank with the loss of over 1,000 lives. Attacks by Japanese land-based aircraft inflicted some damage on US naval forces, but little in relation to their own losses of pilots and machines.

In the hope of at least dying to some effect, a group of Japanese pilots volunteered to carry out suicide attacks, crashing their aircraft into enemy ships. The first American ship sunk by kamikaze pilots was the escort carrier USS *St. Lo* on 25 October.

THE END OF AN ERA

The battle almost ended badly for the Americans. After the sinking of the *Musashi*, Halsey accepted the bait of the decoy Japanese carriers and pursued them to destruction. In the absence of the main American carrier force, Japanese heavy cruisers slipped through the San Bernadino Strait and surprised escort carriers and destroyers supporting the troop landings. The US Navy was briefly at the mercy of Japanese naval guns, but bold torpedo runs by the destroyers and attacks by aircraft from the escort carriers drove the Japanese off. Having lost three battleships, eight cruisers and four carriers, the Imperial Navy had fought its last major battle.